



The Mascalonge — chromolithograph by S. F. Denton, New York Commissioners of Fisheries, Game and Forests, 1896–1902. Public domain; converted to grayscale for printing.

Pattern	Dark bars or spots on a <i>light</i> body — the exact reverse of a northern pike.
Cheek	Lower half of <i>both</i> the cheek and the gill cover is scaleless.
Jaw pores	Six to nine per side. A pike has five or fewer.
Tail	Lobes come to sharper points than a pike’s.
Minimum	40 in, 1 per day, open water only.

Why this sheet exists

Muskellunge are **not** among the species the DNR lists as common in Pine Lake or North Lake. They are nonetheless regulated on both waters, at a 40 in minimum and one fish per day. If you hook a large esocid here it is almost certainly a northern pike — but you must be able to prove that to yourself before you decide what to do with it, because the two fish carry different minimum lengths and different seasons.

Musky or pike? Three checks, in order

1. Pattern	Musky: dark bars or spots on a light background. Pike: light bean-shaped spots on a dark background. The two are photographic negatives of one another.
2. Cheek & gill cover	Look at the side of the head. Musky: the lower half of <i>both</i> the cheek and the gill cover is scaleless. Pike: the whole cheek is scaled; only the lower gill cover is bare.
3. Jaw pores	Turn the head and count the pores along one side of the underside of the lower jaw. Musky: six to nine. Pike: five or fewer. This is the check that settles an argument.
Tail	A musky’s tail lobes come to sharper points; a pike’s are more rounded. Useful as confirmation, not as the deciding test.
Tiger musky	A pike-musky hybrid, with bold wavy bars and rounded tail lobes. It falls under the musky regulations.

If you do hook one

Decide fast	Measure it in the net, in the water. Under 40 in it goes back, full stop.
Gear	A big musky cannot be landed responsibly on panfish tackle. A large net, long pliers, jaw spreaders and bolt cutters for a buried hook are the minimum.
Release	Keep it horizontal and in the water. A musky is a long, heavy fish and its own weight in air injures it. Revive it facing into the current or move it gently forward until it swims off under its own power.
Season	Open water only, 2 May–31 December — unlike pike, there is no ice season for musky.

Worth knowing

Slow, old and few	Muskellunge grow slowly and live fifteen to twenty years or more. A 40 in fish is well into double-digit age. There is no such thing as a common musky.
Top of the chain, top of the mercury	Long life plus a diet of other predators is exactly the recipe for accumulating mercury, which is why Wisconsin's health guidance puts musky in a category of its own. <i>see the Cooking Muskellunge sheet</i>
They follow without eating	A musky commonly tracks a lure to the boat and turns away. This is normal behaviour, not a missed opportunity, and it is why musky anglers finish every cast with a figure-eight at the boat.
The pore count is the legal test	Six to nine pores per side of the lower jaw on a musky, five or fewer on a pike. At a 40 in minimum against 26 in, being able to do that check in ten seconds is a legal matter, not a trivia question.
The tail lobes	Pointed on a musky, rounded on a pike. A useful confirmation once the pattern and the pores agree.

Regulations on these waters, 2026–27. 40 in minimum, 1 per day, open water only, 2 May–31 December. A misidentified fish is still a violation. *These change; only the Wisconsin DNR's current publication for this exact water body is authoritative.*

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